

BY ARVIND SHARMA

SECULAR POLITICKING

Asymmetrical secularism as practised in India breeds intolerance of both arrogance and resentment. Modi's victory is a rejoinder to its evils.

The decisive victory of Narendra Modi will be viewed by those opposed to him as a setback for secularism and a sordid victory for communalism. The fact, however, that Gujarat continues to produce the same electoral outcome so convincingly and successfully should involve some introspection. To view the outcome solely in Manichean terms may be morally comforting but could be analytically inadequate. How has Modi succeeded in 'fooling' all the people all the time (until now)? In the face of conventional wisdom such a persistent outcome is not possible.

Could it be that the so-called polarisation is not between the two communities but between two forms of secularism, in which one of the communities has become symbolic of a certain kind of asymmetrical secularism as opposed to the genuine product?

Secularism can be practised at several levels. It could take the form of the neutrality of the state in relation to religion, when a wall of separation sets the two apart. The fact that India has no state religion serves to illustrate this form of secularism. Or it could take the form of impartiality of the state in relation to the various religions. Thus the Indian government regulates both Hindu endowments and Waqf property. Or it could take the form of harmony among religions being promoted by the state.

An asymmetry seems to pervade the whole issue of secularism in India at the moment and the verdict of Gujarat is arguably the most recent expression of this state of affairs. The prime minister publicly states that Muslims have the first claim on the resources of the country, a statement one could well imagine emanating from

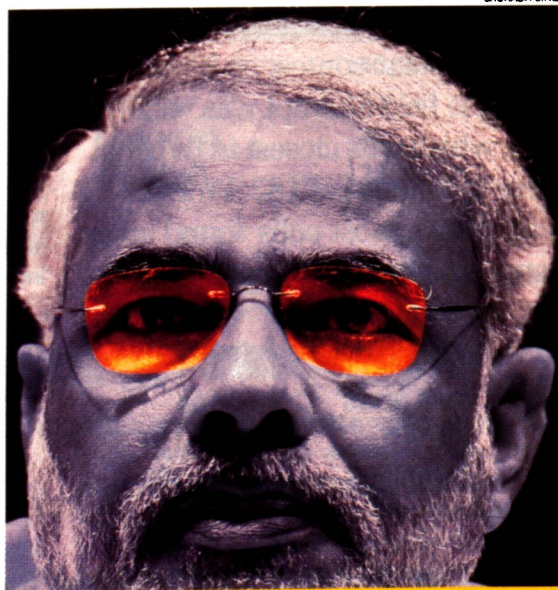
across the border, from an Islamic state. He must have had poor Muslims in mind but that unexceptionable sentiment was poorly expressed. He doubtless possesses a similar sympathy for poor Hindus, Christians, Sikhs and others but they went unrecognised, and the neutrality of the state was easily compromised. Although the state regulates religious institutions of both—Hindus and others—its regulation of such matters is constrained by the rights of the minorities enshrined in the Constitution. There are, how-

ever, no such constraints when it deals with the majority religion.

Such asymmetry is even more glaring in the discourse on secularism. The Hindus who perished in the train in Godhra experienced death without martyrdom, while Afzal Guru, a convicted terrorist, becomes a martyr without death, a martyr for secularism. The prime minister openly lashes out at the chief minister of a state as communal, but is not considered so himself even though his government was all set to order a headcount in the armed forces according to religion. The killings in Gujarat are invoked with talismanic frequency but a sinister silence surrounds the issue of Kashmiri pundits. When the so-called communalists try to focus on development as the electoral agenda, it is the "secular forces" which prevent this from happening, when the merchants from Venice label them merchants of death and so on.

Asymmetrical secularism breeds religious intolerance. It breeds the intolerance of arrogance in those who benefit from it, and the intolerance of resentment in those who are at its receiving end. It creates the paradox of both the majority and the minority nurturing grievances simultaneously. It pushes the members of all religions into the narrow confines of their own traditions. Fanaticism consists in standing so close to one's own religious tradition as to be blinded by the intensity of its luminosity, instead of seeing the whole world transfigured in its light.

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SAURABH SINGH

THE HINDUS WHO DIED IN THE TRAIN AT GODHRA EXPERIENCED DEATH WITHOUT MARTYRDOM WHILE AFZAL GURU IS A MARTYR WITHOUT DEATH

